

The Planets Gather for a Show in the Evening Sky

All seven major planets form a kind of parade in the sky at the end of February. Although two of the planets are not visible to the unaided eye, all are on the same side of the sun during the evening hours.

This planetary grouping happens when the planets appear to line up in the night sky as seen from Earth. They do not form a straight line, but they do stretch across the evening sky this year.

The American space agency, NASA, says these astronomical gatherings are common. A parade of four or five planets visible to the unaided eye happens every few years.

A similar parade took place last June, but only two planets could be seen without the use of special equipment. Six planets were visible in January. Four were visible to the unaided eye. In recent weeks, Mercury joined the group.

The planets Venus, left, and Jupiter, right, with three of its moons visible, appear close to each other in the sky above tree branches after dusk Wednesday, July 1, 2015, in Tacoma, Wash.

Venus, Mars and Jupiter are all easily visible in the evening. Saturn is now very close to the setting sun and Mercury is close to the horizon, making both hard to see. Uranus and Neptune are the most distant planets. Uranus can be glimpsed with binoculars or a telescope under good conditions. But Neptune is now too close to the sun to be seen.

Seeing the brightest planets is easy. Go outside on a clear night after sunset. The planets will shine brighter than the stars. Mars is a bright, reddish-orange light appearing high in the constellation Gemini. Jupiter is very bright and a little lower than Mars toward the constellation Taurus.

Venus, in the constellation of Pisces, is the brightest natural object in the sky besides the sun and moon.

There are many stargazing apps available that can help identify the planets and bright stars.

The planets will slowly move lower and lower in the west throughout the spring.

I'm Mario Ritter, Jr.

Adithi Ramakrishnan reported this story for the Associated Press. Mario Ritter, Jr. adapted it for VOA Learning English.

Vocabulary

visible - adj. ที่สามารถมองเห็นได้ด้วยตาเปล่า

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. According to Paragraph 2, how many major planets are part of the 'parade' observed at the end of February?

- Two
- Four
- Seven
- Five

2. In the planetary parade described in Paragraph 2, how many planets are NOT visible to the unaided eye?

- Two
- Three
- Five
- Seven

3. Based on Paragraph 3, what is the nature of the 'planetary grouping' mentioned in the article?

- The planets align in a perfectly straight line in the night sky.
- The planets are physically very close to each other in space.
- The planets appear to line up from Earth's perspective, stretching across the sky.
- The planets only appear individually without any specific pattern.

4. What does NASA state about the commonality of these astronomical gatherings and the frequency of a visible parade of four or five planets?

- They are rare events that happen once in a lifetime.
- They are uncommon, occurring only every few decades.
- They are common, with a parade of four or five visible planets happening every few years.
- NASA believes these gatherings are mere optical illusions.

5. How many planets were visible without special equipment during the similar parade mentioned in 'last June'?

- Six
- Four

Two

Seven

6. In January, according to Paragraph 5, how many planets were visible to the unaided eye?

Two

Four

Six

All seven

7. Which two planets were observed appearing close to each other in Tacoma, Wash., on July 1, 2015?

Mars and Jupiter

Venus and Mars

Venus and Jupiter

Saturn and Mercury

8. Which of the following planets are mentioned as being 'easily visible in the evening' in Paragraph 7?

Saturn, Mercury, and Uranus

Venus, Mars, and Jupiter

Neptune, Uranus, and Saturn

Mercury, Jupiter, and Neptune

9. According to Paragraph 7, what makes Saturn and Mercury hard to see?

They are the most distant planets.

They are too small to be seen without a telescope.

Saturn is close to the setting sun, and Mercury is close to the horizon.

They only appear during daytime hours.

10. How can Uranus be viewed under good conditions, according to Paragraph 7?

It is easily visible to the unaided eye.

It can be glimpsed with binoculars or a telescope.

It is too close to the sun to be seen.

Only professional observatories can see it.

11. What is a key characteristic that helps distinguish planets from stars in the night sky, as mentioned in Paragraph 8?

Planets appear to twinkle more brightly than stars.

Planets are always much larger in apparent size than stars.

Planets shine brighter than the stars.

Planets are always found in specific constellations, unlike stars.

12. In which constellation does Mars appear high, as described in Paragraph 8?

Taurus

Pisces

Gemini

Orion

13. What is stated about Venus's brightness in Paragraph 9?

It is brighter than Jupiter but not as bright as Mars.

It is the brightest natural object in the sky, including the sun and moon.

It is the brightest natural object in the sky, apart from the sun and moon.

Its brightness varies significantly depending on the season.

14. According to the text, what can help identify planets and bright stars, and what is predicted about the planets' movement during the spring?

Special telescopes are required, and planets will move higher in the east.

Stargazing apps are available, and planets will move lower in the west.

Only expert astronomers can identify them, and planets will remain stationary.

No specific tools are mentioned, and planets will disappear from view.

15. Who was responsible for adapting the story for VOA Learning English?

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The Associated Press

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NASA